how to survive in a world where there is no agency to protect them from each other' and that 'they quickly realize that power is the key to their survival'. Mearsheimer then asks 'how much power states want' and answers that all states want as much power as they can get, 'because the international system creates powerful incentives for states to look for opportunities to gain power at the expense of rivals'. He concludes, 'A state's ultimate goal is to be the hegemon in the system.'[45]

This grim view of international relations is akin to the populist and Marxist views of human relations, in that they all see humans as interested only in power. And they are all founded upon a deeper philosophical theory of human nature, which the primatologist Frans de Waal termed 'veneer theory'. It argues that at heart humans are Stone Age hunters who cannot but see the world as a jungle where the strong prey upon the weak and where might makes right. For millennia, the theory goes, humans have tried to camouflage this unchanging reality under a thin and mutable veneer of myths and rituals, but we have never really broken free from the law of the jungle. Indeed, our myths and rituals are themselves a weapon used by the jungle's top dogs to deceive and trap their inferiors. Those who don't realise this are dangerously naive and will fall prey to some ruthless predator.[46]

There are reasons to think, however, that 'realists' like Mearsheimer have a selective view of historical reality and that the law of the jungle is itself a myth. As de Waal and many other biologists documented in numerous studies, real jungles – unlike the one in our imagination – are full of cooperation, symbiosis and altruism displayed by countless animals, plants, fungi and even bacteria. Eighty per cent of all land plants, for example, rely on symbiotic relationships with fungi, and almost 90 per cent of vascular plant families enjoy symbiotic relationships with microorganisms. If organisms in the rain forests of Amazonia, Africa or India abandoned cooperation in favour of an all-out competition for hegemony, the rain forests and all their inhabitants would quickly die. That's the law of the jungle.[47]

As for Stone Age humans, they were gatherers as well as hunters, and there is no firm evidence that they had irrepressible warlike tendencies. While there are plenty of speculations, the first unambiguous evidence for organised warfare appears in the archaeological record only about thirteen thousand years ago, at the site of Jebel Sahaba in the Nile valley.[48] Even